

Universally Accessible Canoe and Kayak Launches

Mark Brochu, Director, St. Clair County Parks and Recreation

Kim Haller, Director, Midland County Parks and Recreation

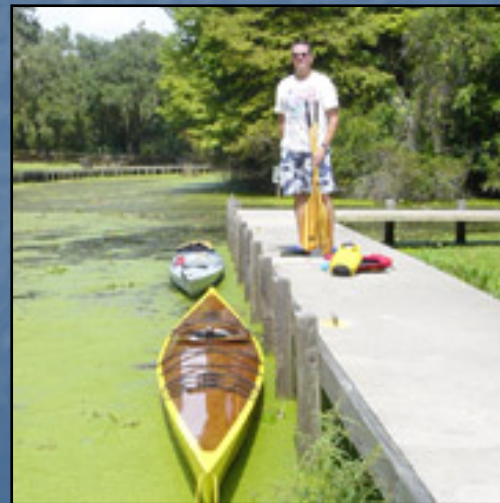
Pam Blough, Landscape Architect, PM Blough, Inc.



Revised 2/23/09

Why new launches are needed

- Many canoe and kayak launches are open bank areas.
- There is not easy parking or walkways.
- Hard to get into the river.
- Lots of tipping when getting in and out.



The Vision

- To develop a canoe and kayak launch that would expand recreational opportunities to more persons who are currently limited by the existing facilities.
- To further the Access to Recreation goals.



Reasons to Share the Design

- To develop a launch that can be used throughout the state that is similar so persons can travel around to different rivers.
- To share the development costs & ideas.
- More people involved; more ideas.



Limiting Factors

- Obvious disabilities such as wheelchair users.
- Hip and knee replacements.
- Back injuries.
- Limited ability to carry canoes & kayaks.
- Balance and difficulty at getting in.
- “If I could only get in without getting wet.”



Assumptions

- That all users would have some upper body movement in order to enter and paddle.
- Persons would make their own adaptations to the vessel to fit their special needs, or use as purchased.
- Some persons could come alone to the launch while other would be accompanied.
- The launch had to be durable to withstand general public park use and vandalism attempts.
- Launch compliant with MDEQ requirements.



Goals

- To provide use by a variety of kayakers and canoes already commercially available.
- To develop the launch for river use rather than lake.
- Develop a launch that does not require electricity.
- Easy to figure out how to use.
- Operated by a single person or does not require additional assistance.



Basic Facility Items

■ Parking

- Accessible parking spaces for vehicle and boat trailer. (Not just a car parking space)
- More accessible spaces than required by law.
- Easy surface to roll canoes and kayaks on wheels to and from launch.
- Relatively solid surface for knee and hip replacement persons.



Access Route

- An ADA accessible surface for a walkway between the parking lot and the launch for people and for rolling boats.
- Should be at least 12' wide to allow for two persons utilizing wheelchairs to carry a canoe between them.
- Slope needs to be as gentle as possible, but less than 5%.
- Access route accommodates seasonal in and out of launch.



Picture this with a wheelchair or walker on each side

Launch

- Room to maneuver a canoe or kayak on the launch.
- A way to steady the canoe and kayak.
- Assistance with something to hold onto.
- Ability to transfer into the canoes in a variety of ways.



NOT good examples.



Site Amenities

- Additional Site Elements Could Include

- Picnic Tables
- Toilet Facilities
- Group Staging Areas
- Maps of the River & Points of Interest
- Locations of other Accessible Launches



Midland's Chippewa River

- The Chippewa Nature Center & Midland County Parks.
- Desire to create a series of five launches within Midland.
- Use by public for recreation.
- Use by Nature Center for canoe and kayak classes and outings.
- Support the idea of being part of a state-wide system of accessible launches.



St. Clair County Water Trail

- County wants to lead the development of water trails throughout the County.
- Access sites at County and local parks.
- Looking to develop a standard launch consistently available at all of the sites.
- Support the idea of being part of a state-wide system.



The Design Began in Midland

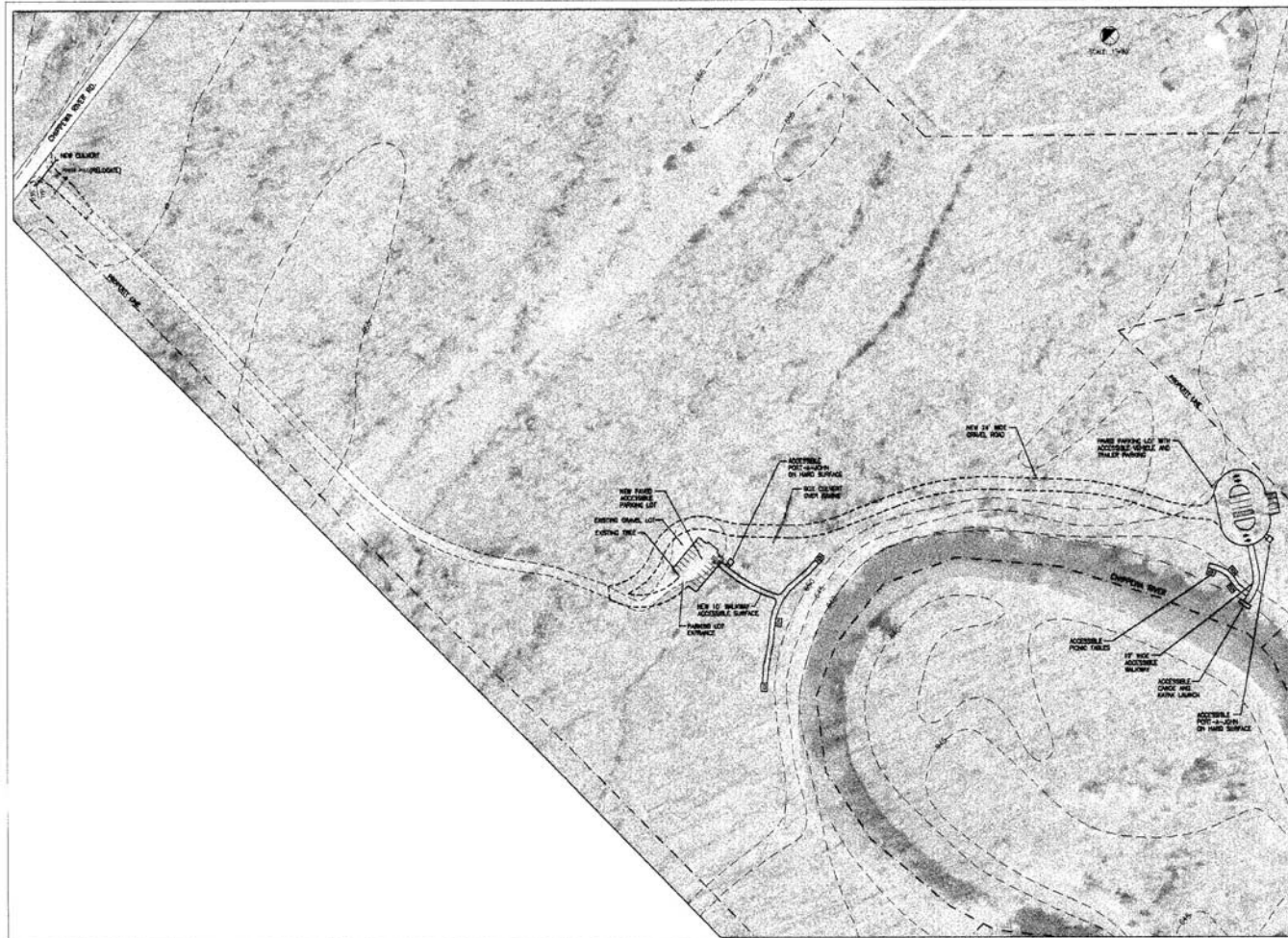


Manitou County Park
Midland County Parks



Chippewa Cabin Property
Chippewa Nature Center

Preliminary Site Drawings



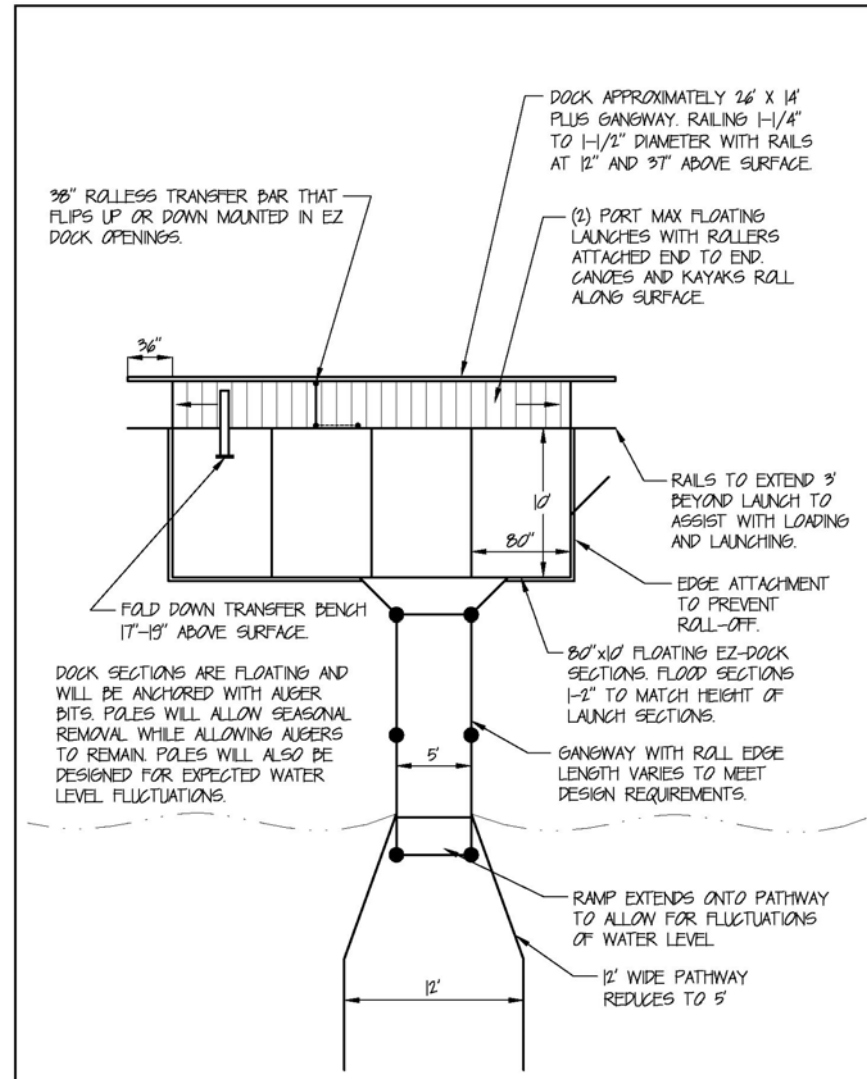
SITE PLAN NANTOU PA

P.M. Blough, Inc.

F.M. Blough, Inc.
1640 Gladys Ave.
Grand Haven, MI 49417
Telephone: (616) 847-2010

**MIDLAND CANOE LAUNCHES
MANITOU PARK
MIDLAND COUNTY PARKS**

Preliminary Design



ACCESSIBLE CANOE AND KAYAK LAUNCH

PREPARED BY:
P.M. BLOUGH INC.

03-28-08

SHEET 1 OF 1

Manitou Park



Chippewa Cabin Site



SCALE: 1"=30'

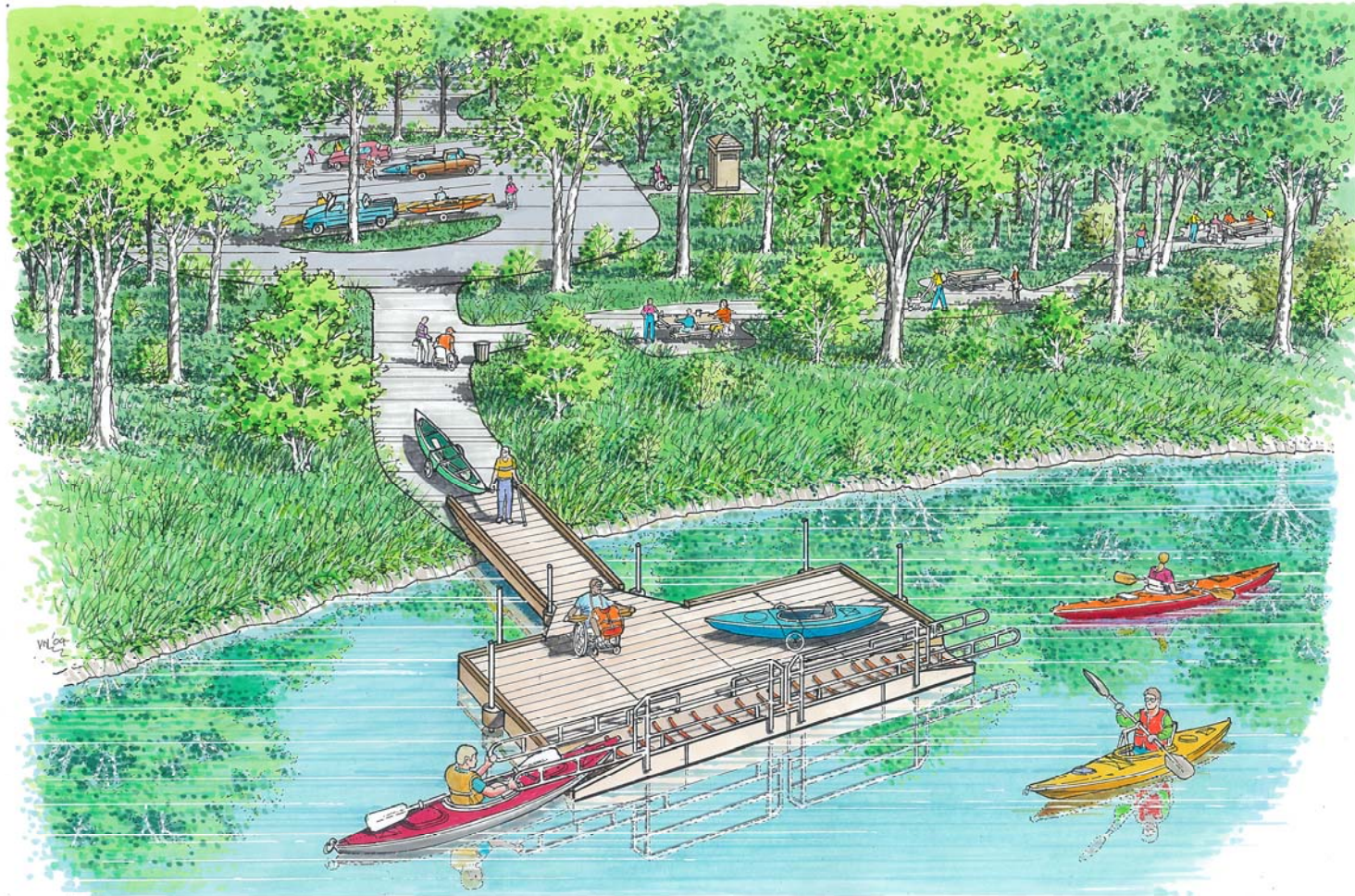
P.M. Blough, Inc.

1840 Gladys Ave.
Grand Haven, MI 49417
Telephone: (616) 847-2010

**MIDLAND CANOE LAUNCHES
CHIPPewa CABIN PROPERTY
CHIPPewa NATURE CENTER**

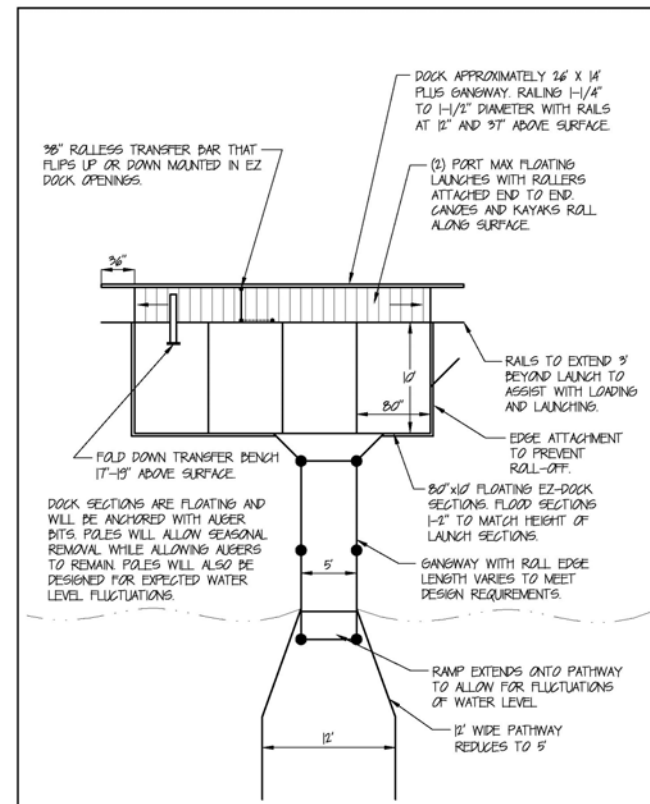
CHIPPewa CABIN SITE PLAN

Chippewa Cabin Site



St. Clair County Launch Trial

- Install the basic launch to see if it will really work.
- Try this much of the design prior to figuring out the unsolved wheel chair transfer.
- Get some real people trying it and giving feedback



ACCESSIBLE CANOE AND KAYAK LAUNCH

PREPARED BY:
P.M. BLAUGH IN

03-28-08

SHEET 1 OF 1

North River Road Park

The first launch is delivered in September 2008 to St. Clair County.

The launch is delivered to the park site. All of the parts are pre-manufactured.



The launch sections are unloaded into the river.



The sections
are connected
together.



The poles are installed to hold the launch from floating away.

The roll edge is installed along the outside edges of the docks.





- The finished trial launch

The launch





The First Launch













Testimonials from Users

“ Descending the ramp was beautiful. Getting in and out on the dock is so much easier since it is a dry dock and the worry of tipping the craft has been eliminated.

Thanks for the great idea! Keep up the great work.”

-Brenda Easton

“This note is to thank you and congratulate you for the purchase and installation of the canoe/kayak launch at the North River Road Park on the Black River. We have used it several times and have found it to be extremely helpful for entering and exiting the river. The design has made Tom who has an artificial hip, feel secure climbing in and out of his kayak. In fact, he bought his kayak after seeing the launch.”

-Laurie and Tom Dennis

Sign at Launch



This Canoe & Kayak Launch is a prototype being developed by the St. Clair County Parks and Recreation Commission under an Access to Recreation grant funded by the Kellogg Foundation through the St. Clair County Community Foundation.

The goal of the grant is to design, develop and build universally accessible recreation facilities for residents and guests of all abilities. In the case of this launch system, our goal is to have a facility that makes launching and retrieving canoes and kayaks easy for paddlers of all abilities.

We have installed this proto-type in order to test the basic design of the launch. We would like to get feedback from users of all abilities on what they like and what ideas they have for improving the launch system. Comments and suggestions can be sent to the St. Clair County Park and Recreation Office at the following:

Telephone: (810) 989-6960
Fax: (810) 985-3762
Email: mbrochu@stclaircounty.org

The next step in the development of the launch is to make improvements to the basic design and begin developing, fabricating and installing devices that will allow people with disabilities to use the launch including transfer boards and additional railings.

This launch and others will be installed at accessible sites throughout St. Clair County in the coming years. All sites will have to provide an accessible, paved route from the parking area to the launch.

For more information on the Access to Recreation program visit:
www.accesstorec.org

Launch Conceptual Costs

- St. Clair County
 - Purchase of launch as shown
\$22,000 installed
- Chippewa Cabin Property
 - Launch, parking lot, drive, walkway,
picnic tables, signage
\$143,000 conceptual estimate

Goals Reached to Date

- The launch is providing additional recreational opportunities for canoe and kayaking through a new solution.
- The launch itself works.
- Design of desired site development needs and solutions are ready for development.



The Wheel Chair Transfer Challenge

- Pursuing the idea of a fold down transfer board and assist bars
- Attempted to work with an engineering school to design the transfers mechanisms but were unsuccessful due to timing and fees.
- Working with a local medial equipment provider to try to locate any existing products that are already on the market that can be used on the launch.
- Working with EZ Dock engineers to explore options that can be designed and offered as apart of their EZ Launch.



Other Challenges

- The lack of interest of some vendors to help look at alternative designs.
- Patent rights.
- Fund raising.
- People willing to think beyond the wheel chair user to other users.



The Future

- Complete the construction of a launch site complete with parking, walkway, and site amenities.
- Solve the transfer challenge.
- Expand the solution farther than Midland and St. Clair Counties.



Contact Information

- **Mr. Mark Brochu, CPRP**

St. Clair County Parks & Recreation Commission
Phone: (810) 989-6960
Email: MBrochu@stclaircounty.org

- **Mr. Kim Haller**

Midland County Parks & Recreation
Phone: (989) 832-6876
Email: khaller@co.midland.mi.us

- **Ms. Pam Blough, ASLA**

P.M. Blough, Inc.
Phone: (616) 847-2010
Email: pamblough@aol.com

